



Commanding start: Appointed ahead of the 2023–25 WTC cycle, Temba Bavuma has led South Africa to nine wins in his first 10 Tests as captain — a remarkable start to his leadership tenure. REUTERS

when a batter also uses the back foot are far greater than off the front foot, but apart from Steve Smith, most of the modern batters with their legs spread wide in the stance are unable to transfer the balance to their back foot and so miss out on more scoring opportunities.

While there would be questions asked about the fall of 32 wickets in the first three days, most had to do with the fallout of the T20 format and not much to do with the pitch. The T20 format makes a batter look to clear his front foot so he can swing his bat freely for the lofted shot. At the Test level though, and that too in England with the Dukes ball, it is crucial

for the batter to get his front foot as close to the ball as possible to negate the movement. Most batters got out playing away from their body, possibly because of coming to the Test match after the IPL. Markram made the adjustment beautifully after his first-innings duck, where he too got out playing away from his leg guards. **A wonderful century, and as he said, the most important runs he has ever scored for his country.**

Those runs and the lion-hearted bowling of Kagiso Rabada and Lungi Ngidi helped South Africa to a long-awaited world title in cricket, and hopefully removed the chokers tag forever.



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